Carrie

By Stephen King

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Carrie White's mother Margaret White gave birth to her daughter September 21, 1963 under circumstances that can only be termed bizarre.*
ACTRESS 2: *In fact, an overview of the Carrie White case leaves the careful student with one feeling ascendant over all others: that Carrie was the only issue of a family as odd as any that has ever been brought to popular attention.*
ACTRESS 1: *We know that Carrie was the victim of her mother's religious mania*
ACTRESS 2: *We know that she possessed a latent telekinetic talent, commonly referred to as TK.*
ACTRESS 1: *How apparent was Carrie's "wild talent" and what did Margaret White, with her extreme Christian ethic, think of it?*
ACTRESS 2: *We shall probably never know. But one is tempted to believe that Mrs. White's reaction must have been extreme . . .*
TOGETHER: *Carrie by Stephen King*

Dinner time at the White's house . . .

MARGARET: You haven't touched your pie, Carrie. It's homemade.

CARRIE: It makes me have pimples, Momma.

MARGARET: Your pimples are the Lord's way of chastising you. Now eat your pie.

CARRIE: Momma?

MARGARET: Yes?

CARRIE: I've been invited to the Spring Ball next Friday by Tommy Ross -- *(Margaret stares at her with wide my-ears-are-deceiving-me eyes. Her nostrils flare. Carrie gets a lump in her throat and is visibly afraid)* – and he's a very nice boy. He's promised to stop in and meet you before and . . .

MARGARET: No.

CARRIE: -- to have me in by eleven. I've –

MARGARET: No, no, *no!*

CARRIE: --accepted. Momma, please see that I have to start to . . . to try and get along with

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the world. I'm not like you. I'm funny – I mean the kids think I'm funny. I don't want to be. I want to try and be a whole person before it's too late to . . . *(Margaret throws her tea in Carrie's face and sits trembling. Her face frozen except for her nostrils which continue to flare. Abruptly she throws back her head and screams at the ceiling)*

MARGARET: God! God! God! *(Carrie does not move. Margaret hands hook into shaking class. Her face is half-mad – compassion mixed with hate).* The closet. Go to your closet and pray. And God made Eve from the rib of Adam. Let us pray. Let us pray to Jesus for our woman-weak, wicked, sinning souls.

CARRIE: *(sobbing quietly)* Momma . . .

MARGARET: And Eve was weak and loosed the raven on the world, and the first Sin was Intercourse, And the Lord visited Eve with a Curse, and the Curse was the Curse of Blood. And Adam and Eve were driven out of the Garden and into the World and Eve found that her belly had grown big with child.

CARRIE: Momma! Momma, please listen. It wasn't my fault! . . . You should have told me!!

MARGARET: O Lord, help this sinning woman beside me here see the sin of her days and ways. Show her that if she had remained sinless the Curse of Blood never would have come on her.

CARRIE: No: Let me go!

MARGARTE: Show here that this is Your kind, vengeful hand at work and Your sign that she must walk the straight and narrow from her on out if she is to avoid the flaming agoinies of the Eternal Pit. Amen . . . *(a beat then quietly)* Boys. Yes, boys come next. After the blood the boys come. Like sniffing dogs, grinning and slobbering, trying to find out where that smell is. *That . . . smell! (She swings her whole arm into the blow and slaps Carrie's face. Carrie remains seated although her upper body sways. The mark on her check is first white, then blood red.)* The mark . . . *(Her eyes are large but blank. She is breathing rapidly and seems to be talking to herself as she pulls Carrie out of her chair).* I've seen it, all right. Oh, yes. But. I. Never. Did. But for him. He. Took. Me . . . .

CARRIE: *(Terrified)* Momma . . .

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MARGARET: In cars. Oh, I know where they take you in their cars. City limits. Roadhouses. Whiskey. Smelling . . . *oh they smell it on you! (her voice rises to a scream. Tendons stand out in her neck and her head twists in a questing upward rotation)*

CARRIE: Momma, you better stop. *(Margaret snaps back to some kind of hazy reality)*

MARGARET: The closet. Go to your closet and pray.

CARRIE: No. *(Momma raises her hand to strike)* ***No!*** *(her hand stops in the dead air – Carrie is controlling it with her TK)* I'm going, Momma! *(Margaret drops to her knees with her hands over her head)*

MARGARET: *(moaning)* Devil's child. Devil's child. Satan spawn . . .

CARRIE: Momma, stand up.

MARGARET: lust and licentiousness, the cravings of the flesh . . .

CARRIE: Stand up! *(Margaret's voice stops, but she stand with her hands still on her head, like a prisoner of war. Her lips move as if reciting the Lord's Prayer)* I don't want to fight with you, Momma. *(her voice breaks, but she tries to control it)* I only want to be let to live my own life. I . . . don't like yours. *(She stops – horrified – she has spoken the ultimate blasphemy)*

MARGARET: *(Whispering)* Witch. It says in the Lord's Book: Thou shalt not suffer a witch to live. Your father did the Lord's work . .

CARRIE: *(her mouth trembling) Momma*

MARGARET: I should have killed myself when he put it in me. After the first time, before we were married, he promised. Never again. He said we just . . . slipped. I believed him. I fell down and I lost the baby and that was God's judgment. I felt that the sin had been expiated. By Blood. But sin never dies. Sin . . . never . . . dies!

CARRIE: *(dropping to her knees and rocking herself for comfort. She has heard this ranting story before)* Momma. I . . .

MARGARET: At first it was all right. We lived sinlessly. We slept in the same bed, belly to belly sometimes, and o, I could feel the presence of the Serpent, but we . never did . until . *(Margaret begins to grin, a hard, terrible grin)* And that night I could see him looking at me

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That Way. We got down on our knees to pray for strength and he . . . touched me. In that place. That woman place. And I sent him out of the house. He was gone for hours, and I prayed for him. I could see him in my mind's eye, walking the midnight streets, wrestling with the devil as Jacob wrestled with the Angel of the Lord. And when he came back my heard was filled with thanksgiving.

CARRIE: Momma, I don't want to hear it!

MARGARET: It wasn't until he came in that I smelled the whisky on his breath. And he took me. Took me! With the stink of filthy roadhouse whiskey sill on him he took me . . and I liked it! *(screaming out the last words at the ceiling)*

CARRIE: ***MOMMA!*** *(Margaret breaks off as if slapped and blinks at her daughter. She continues in a more normal tone of voice.)*

MARGARET: I almost killed myself. And Ralph wept and talked about atonement and I didn't and then he was dead and I thought God had visited me with cancer; that he was turning my female parts into something as black and rotten as my sinning soul. But that would have been too easy. The Lord words in mysterious ways His wonders to perform. I see that now. When the pains began I went and got a knife *(picks up a carving knife from the dinner table)* this knife *(holds it up)* and waited for you to come so I could make my sacrifice. But I was weak and backsliding. I took this knife in hand again when you were three, and I backslid again. So now the devil has come home. *(she holds up the knife her eyes fastened hypnotically on the blade)*

CARRIE: It's not right, Momma. It's not . . .

MARGARET: Let's pray. For the last time, let us pray!

CARRIE: Oh, Momma help me! *(Carrie bows her head in prayer as Margaret lifts the knife to bring it down in a shining arc. At the last moment, Carrie jerks back and once again controls her mother's descending hand with the power of TK. Her hand stops in mid air. They stare at each other in silence, then Carrie speaks softly)* I'm going to give you a present, Momma.

MARGARET: What are you doing?

CARRIE: I'm picturing your heart, Momma. It's easier when you see things in your mind. Hour

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heart is a big red muscle. Mine goes faster when I use my power. But yours is going a little slower now. Slower. Things are going to change around her, Momma. *(Margaret is whispering to herself again – it is not the Lord's Prayer. It is the Prayer of Exorcism from Deuteronomy).* Slower, Momma. Do you know what the present is, Momma? What you always wanted. Darkness. And whatever God lives there."

MARGARET: *(whispering, having difficulty breathing)* Our Father, Who art in heaven . . .

CARRIE: Slower, Momma, Slower.

MARGARET . . . hallowed by They name . . .

CARRIE: I can see the blood draining back into you. Slower.

MARGARET: . . . Thy kingdom come . . .

CARRIE: Your feet and hands like marble, like alabaster. White.

MARGARET: . . . Thy will be done . . .

CARRIE: ***MY*** will, Momma. Slower.

MARGARET: on earth

CARRIE: Slower

MARGARET: as . . . as . . . as it . . . *(she collapses, hands twitching)* as it is in heaven

CARRIE: *(whispering)* Full stop. *(Carrie gradually comes back to her senses and notices her mother on the ground – she crumples into tears over her mother's dead body)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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